



CHARACTER TEST: Deshpande creates moments of intense vulnerability in a life full of choices

The Constant Gardener

In her new novel, the mistress of middle-class morality creates yet another character who is at once heroic and ordinary



IN THE COUNTRY OF DECEIT
by SHASHI DESHPANDE
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■ By Geeta Doctor

It's somewhat like a Satyajit Ray interior. The setting is as important as the genteel folk who inhabit it. There is a hint of melancholy about the place, made tangible by the physical details that Shashi Deshpande provides. It could be the scent of the earth pervading the cool floors of a crumbling old mansion, filled with stories that unfurl with a certain precision that the auteur/author has decided she must explore with the diligence of an archaeologist, uncovering lives brick by brick, or delicately sifting through the layers until a pattern emerges. She works with a lapidary skill placing fragments of bone, skin, hair, voices, words, memories that she sets within a frame as exact as one of Ray's celebrated "scenes".

It is this sense of being a part of Deshpande's own intense involvement that makes for the exhilaration of her writing. She tests readers by her insistence that they attend as intently to what she has to reveal. Though she gives the appearance of being cautious and circumspect by nature, bound as it were by her middle-class morality, she has consistently sought to push open these barriers of the mind and heart. She dares to open doors to various rooms in the house of her middle-class characters in each one of her books, so that despite their apparently banal and even irritatingly prosaic aspirations, they ultimately emerge as heroic. That is to say, Deshpande forces her characters to choose. Perhaps that is also what gives a slightly dated quality to her oeuvre. Free will? The right of the individual to choose his or her own path are surely a given today and not something that needs to be debated. Deshpande's skill is in locating her characters within a

network of familial bonds and duties and then watching how these shape and inform the choices that they make, sometimes the patterns repeating themselves just as surely as a recessive gene makes itself felt while skipping a generation. There is an epic quality that she brings to her portraits of families in a time of flux and disintegration of group identities.

This is particularly true of the narrator of her latest book, *Devayani Mudhal*. She is a graduate of law, like Deshpande herself. She chooses to live alone in a small town in Karnataka, after the death of both her parents in the family house that at the start of the story has been torn down and rebuilt. Her particular joy is in the creation of a garden full of plants and flowers, including what seems a charming conceit, a pond just for frogs. Soon, enough *Devayani* finds herself at the centre of various disparate forces that seem to take over her tranquil life. It's that very quality of inner silence that attracts these elements.

Part of Deshpande's success is in making this seemingly simple young woman so full of a brimming sense of life. This comes to a head when she allows herself to be seduced by a charismatic district superintendent of police Ashok Chinappa. This is the test that Deshpande has set for herself. Can she convey what the book underlines in the two quotations placed as a preface—"A fantasy feast" in the words of A.K. Ramanujam and of love, according to J. Krishnamurti, being "a state of intense vulnerability and beauty"? Though the *Super Policeman* is most often more of a choice hunk in the best Hindu film tradition, *Devayani's* own journey from and into the abyss of sexual fulfilment with a married man and the turmoil it causes within her and her immediate family makes one think that it's a test that Deshpande has passed with honour.

There are moments of intense vulnerability and beauty, so that we too might make the same journey. ■